From Managing Myself to Working Across Cultures

Final Report · Organizational Behavior · Prof. Isabel Villamor · IESE Master in Management 2027, Section B

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Introduction

I finished school at 17 and went straight into an intensive pharmacy degree in Greifswald, which I completed with the state examination. Alongside my studies I ran small businesses, including an Airbnb business and car trading. After an internship in a pharmacy, I went directly into the Master in Management. My goal is a career in the pharmaceutical industry, ideally in a large international company.

This course made me look at that path differently. Three ideas stayed with me, and each one touches something I will carry into my working life:

1. Ambition needs limits (Luis Arrese and Lucía Gómez)
2. Cultural differences cannot be avoided, but they can be managed (Greg James at Sun Microsystems)
3. Big mistakes must be admitted early (YouTube CEO Susan Wojcicki, linked to Bob Knowlton)

1. Ambition needs limits

What prompted it. In the Luis Arrese case, "the locomotive" works almost 80 hours a week and spends eighteen months alone in the United States for his career. His small daughter says "Daddy" when she sees a picture of a telephone.

What I assumed. I recognised myself in Luis more than I liked. I finished school at 17, went straight into an intensive degree, ran businesses on the side, did my pharmacy internship and went directly into the master's. I never questioned this pace; ambition was how I worked, and it brought results. The price was time for people. I go to fewer than half of the birthdays I am invited to. I cancel plans with people I actually like, and they take it personally, as if I did not care about them, which is the opposite of what I feel. At IESE the pattern continues: there is always more workload than anyone can finish.

What changed. Luis does not lack talent or commitment; his problem is allocation. Christensen put it in words I keep thinking about: people with a high need for achievement spend every spare hour where results show fastest and underinvest in relationships, whose returns come years later. It is the sum of many small decisions, and I have been making them since I was 17. I can honestly imagine becoming like Luis, and that scares me.

Connection. The Lucía Gómez case shows where this can lead. She says yes to everything until she breaks down. The well-being lecture gave the positive side: "Good relationships keep us happier and healthier. Period." Its question hit me directly: "Which relationship receives calendar time, and which is left to chance?" For me, the honest answer is that work and studies get calendar time, and friendships are left to chance.

What I learned. If I do not plan time for people deliberately, my calendar will always fill with work first. Ambition and deep friendships only compete when I let the schedule decide for me.

How I will act in the future.

- I have already started: I moved in with two flatmates so that social contact is part of my everyday life. It works well, but it still feels somewhat purpose-driven, and that bothers me. It is a first step, not a solution.
- I will stop overloading myself and learn to be satisfied with doing less. I have never yet dropped a project to do less, and it is a hard step, but I have committed to it.
- I will give friendships fixed calendar time, the way I treat deadlines, and go to the birthdays I am invited to.

Obstacles. My ambition is also my strength, and I do not want to lose it. Right now, in the middle of the MiM and recruiting, changing my habits is hard. That is why I keep a minimum rule: plans with friends stay, even in busy weeks.

2. Cultural differences cannot be avoided, but they can be managed

What prompted it. In the Greg James case, a 45-person team in the US, India, the UAE and France fails a client: an online banking system is down for two hours and nobody responds. Behind the technical errors lie cultural fault lines; an engineer in Mumbai does not call his US colleague, who reportedly called the Indian team incompetent.

What I assumed. I care about connecting cultures, and IESE is a good training ground for it. During my pharmacy internship I already worked with many international people, and my classmates come from Russia, Nigeria, Spain, Italy, England, Sweden, Argentina, Brazil and Mexico. But the case made me see a limit of this training. Most of us here share very similar values: we chose the same school, aim for similar careers and speak the same business language. The people I will work with in a global company may hold very different values. Cooperation across cultures at IESE is real, but it is the easy version.

What changed. So far I have only experienced small difficulties. I am typically German: punctual, conscientious and very direct in person. When a team agrees on a deadline and then submits late, that would rarely happen in Germany, and it frustrated me at first. I did not know that such differences can grow into serious problems for a whole company, up to a lost client and a threatened lawsuit. In a global company they cannot be avoided, but someone who is aware of them can have a real, positive influence. Greg raised customer satisfaction by 72% through process, presence and protection.

Connection. The reading "Managing multicultural teams" offers four responses: adaptation, structural intervention, managerial intervention and exit. I have already used the first: I adapted myself and accepted that I cannot impose my habits on others. In our group projects I also took on a new role as a mediator, helping teammates understand each other and resolving tense situations. The reading on conflict management explains why this matters: differences that are never discussed turn into "conformity", agreement on the surface and resentment underneath.

What I learned. Cultural awareness is not a soft skill on the side. It can decide whether a global team delivers or fails, and I want to use it actively throughout my career.

How I will act in the future.

- In every new team, I will raise working norms early, such as deadlines, feedback and how we decide, instead of assuming everyone shares mine.
- I want to start in a pharmaceutical company because the industry works so internationally, ideally in Sanofi's graduate programme. There I want to keep the mediating role I started at IESE.

- If I lead a global team, I will check who carries the burden of meeting times and whose agenda items always come last.

Obstacles. Adapting takes time, and under deadline pressure it is tempting to fall back on my typically German style. The goal is not to give it up, but to know that it is one style among many.

3. Big mistakes must be admitted early

What prompted it. In the YouTube case, Susan Wojcicki's own product, Google Video, is losing to YouTube. She could have kept going and hoped to catch up. Instead she admits the failure to the board and recommends buying YouTube for $1.65 billion, even though people on her team quit in protest. Her lesson: "When you fail, face your failure — face it head on, admit it, grow from it."

My own mistake. During my studies I traded used cars, mostly out of a passion for cars. Once I bought a car at what looked like a very good price, but it needed far more repairs than expected. After paying for them, it was clear that I would never recover the purchase price plus repairs. Still, I kept the car for nine months, because I did not want to admit the loss, while prices kept falling. When I finally sold it, I had lost about 5,000 euros, paid running costs and tied up money I could have used elsewhere. It hurt. The first rule of car trading is never to hold a car for long, and I broke it out of pride.

The case showed me the same pattern on a very large scale. I remember how stressed I was over one car; Wojcicki made the same kind of decision with $1.65 billion at stake, in public, with employees depending on it. It made me wonder what kind of personality it takes, or how one grows into such a role, to decide calmly.

What changed. Edmondson's spectrum of failure showed me that the error itself is often not the real damage. The damage comes from not admitting it: every week of carrying on adds time, money and credibility to a decision that is already wrong.

Connection. The Bob Knowlton case is the counter-example. He never admits to his boss that he feels overtaken by Fester and finally leaves with a letter full of invented reasons. His boss had planned to move Fester to another project anyway, so one honest conversation would have been enough. Greg James puts the lesson in one sentence: "You are not a failure if they are created on your watch. How you deal with these crises, however, will define your success as a leader."

What I learned. The mistake with the car would not happen to me again. But the case taught me to apply the lesson to every situation: when things go badly, accept the loss, learn from it and look forward. Nobody makes the right decision every time. Admitting a mistake is a strength; refusing to admit it only makes things worse.

How I will act in the future.

- When I trade again, I will set a maximum holding period and a price limit for every car, and sell when either is reached, even at a loss.
- Before I start any project or business, I will define a stop criterion in advance: if X has not happened by date Y, I stop or change course.
- When I notice a mistake, I will tell the people affected within a few days instead of trying to fix it quietly first.

Obstacles. Admitting a mistake costs face, especially when I built the project myself. A stop criterion set in advance helps, because then the decision is made before my pride is involved.

Conclusion

My ambition, my international plans and the way I handle mistakes all work better when I stop treating them as a solo effort. Relationships need calendar time, cultural differences need open attention, and mistakes need to be named early.

Christensen suggests measuring a life not by titles but by the people we help to become better. For someone who has been running at full speed since 17, that is the most useful correction this course offered. I will track three habits: fixed time for friends, explicit working norms in every new team, and a stop criterion for every major project.